Understanding course expectations and procedures

Practical guide for students | D15-ST

Courses may differ in how they organise learning, participation, assessment and support. Find the current information for each course and ask about unfamiliar expectations before they affect your work.

1. Read the course information

Locate the course outline, weekly schedule and official announcements. Identify the learning outcomes, major tasks and teacher contact details. Check which source is updated when arrangements change.

2. Check participation and preparation

Find out what you should do before, during and after class. Clarify expectations for attendance, discussions, group work and independent study. Do not assume these are identical across courses.

3. Map assessment requirements

Record deadlines, task weightings, submission methods and criteria. Check rules about sources, collaboration, translation and AI. Ask about anything that is unclear before using a tool in assessed work.

4. Find procedures you may need

Locate the official processes for absence, technical problems, extensions and other relevant circumstances. Check who to contact and any deadlines. Follow the published procedure rather than relying on informal advice.

5. Check your understanding

Use a practical question: “If I cannot attend the group presentation, who should I contact and what procedure applies?” Ask for a link to the relevant information if needed.

6. Keep a short reference note

Make a personal list of key dates, contacts and links. Review announcements regularly and update your note when instructions change. Confirm conflicting information with the teacher.

7. Example

One course expects a reading response before each tutorial, while another uses an in-class quiz. You record both requirements in your calendar and check where each task is completed. When a deadline changes, you update your plan using the teacher’s official announcement.

8. Quick checklist

☐ I know where current course information is kept.

☐ I understand preparation and participation expectations.

☐ I have recorded assessment dates and rules.

☐ I know where to find relevant procedures.

9. When to seek further support

Ask your teacher about course expectations and student services about institutional procedures. If the language of a policy is difficult, ask for an explanation of the relevant steps. For an urgent issue, contact the responsible service promptly.

10.Supporting sources

RMIT University. (n.d.). New ways of learning. Learning Lab. Open resource

Supports understanding the different forms of learning and responsibilities involved in university study.

RMIT University. (n.d.). Understanding your assignment. Learning Lab. Open resource

Supports checking deadlines, presentation and referencing requirements. Broader course and institutional procedures are local matters.